

Why "Be Yourself" Is the Worst Career Advice for Leaders

****Quick Bridge:**** Every organization tells leaders to "bring their whole self to work." Researchers are now pushing back. Authenticity is not about being who you are. It is about choosing how to show up. This post breaks down why the "be yourself" mandate stalls leaders at the wrong moment, what the research says about impression management and trust, and how to build leadership presence as a deliberate skill rather than a personality type.

The Advice Every Leader Gets Wrong

Organizations love the phrase "bring your whole self to work." It shows up in culture decks, leadership development programs, and onboarding materials. Leaders are told: be authentic, be vulnerable, be real.

The implicit message is clear: being yourself, your natural unguarded self, is what earns trust and builds teams.

The problem is the advice is aimed at the wrong thing.

Most leaders who struggle with presence, influence, or visibility are not struggling because they are hiding who they are. They are struggling because they have been told their natural mode of operating should be enough. When it is not, they feel like something is wrong with them.

The leadership version of themselves feels like a performance. A costume. Something they are relieved to take off.

That guilt is the real problem. And it is rooted in a fundamental misunderstanding of what authenticity actually means.

What Authenticity Research Actually Shows

In 2025, researchers and practitioners began pushing back hard on the "be yourself" narrative. A Columbia Business School professor cited in Fortune argued that [workplace authenticity is overrated](<https://fortune.com/2025/10/09/why-is-workplace-authenticity-overrated-gen-z/>). The research shows that impression management, the deliberate choice of how to present yourself, can actually make you seem more authentic and trustworthy than rigid adherence to your "true self."

This is the authenticity paradox: the harder you try to be exactly who you are at all times, the less effective and relatable you become.

Leaders who let every thought show, every frustration surface, and every discomfort become visible are not building trust. They are making their teams manage them.

What the research does support is this: the four components of effective authentic leadership are self-awareness, relational transparency, an internalized moral perspective, and balanced processing. Notice what is missing from that list. "Being yourself" is not one of them.

Why "Being Yourself" Stalls Leaders at the Wrong Moment

Here is the pattern I see constantly. A strong individual contributor or manager gets promoted. They have been successful by being competent, by solving problems, by being the person who knows things. That version of themselves has worked.

The new role requires something different. More presence. More influence in rooms where they are not the technical expert. More energy in meetings they would rather observe.

The "natural self" in this scenario is often an introvert, or a processor, or a person who prefers listening to performing.

Leaders who were told to "be themselves" hit this moment and either push through with guilt or they pull back. When they push through with guilt, they feel fake every time they show up as a more visible version of themselves. When they pull back, they stay comfortable in their natural mode at the cost of their effectiveness.

Both responses have the same root assumption. Their natural self is the right self for the job.

What the leaders who succeed at this transition have in common is not a personality type. It is a willingness to choose who they want to be in the role, and then practice being that person deliberately.

They do not feel inauthentic. They feel like they are learning a skill.

The Deliberate Choice Model: Four Moves

Separate the Person From the Role

You have a self. You also have a role. They are not the same thing.

Being an introvert does not make you a bad leader. Needing quiet time to recharge does not make you unable to command a room when it matters. The confusion comes from equating natural state with professional identity.

The separation is not about performing a character. It is about recognizing that effective leaders show up differently depending on context. This is not a flaw. This is how humans work.

Get Specific About the Version You Are Choosing to Be

Vague intentions do not produce presence. "I want to be a more confident leader" gives you nothing to practice.

Get specific. Do you want to be the person in the room who asks the sharpest question? The person who stays calm when everyone else is reacting? The person who credits other people publicly before they think to ask?

Choose deliberately. This is not about picking one and being done. These choices compound. You practice one until it becomes automatic, then you take on the next. Start with whatever is most visible right now, and be specific enough that you could describe it to someone else.

The more precise the version you are practicing, the faster it sticks.

Practice the Skill, Not the Feeling

Leadership presence is a performance skill, the same as public speaking or conflict resolution. You would not expect to feel natural on a stage without rehearsing. You would not pick up an instrument and expect to sound polished.

Why do leaders expect presence to feel natural on the first try? It does not.

You practice it. You get feedback. You notice what works. You do it in low-stakes situations before you try it in high-stakes ones. Over time, the gap between "natural self" and "chosen version" closes. Not because you changed who you are, but because you practiced long enough that the choice became automatic.

Recognize When the Skill Has Integrated

This is the part leaders miss. At some point, the version they chose to practice becomes who they are. The choice becomes invisible. The performance becomes natural.

That is not when they have finally become authentic. That is when they have practiced long enough that the choice feels real.

The skill is integrated. The discomfort is gone. And now, people who knew them before the shift do not believe them when they say they were ever uncomfortable in large groups.

The Trust Mechanism

Organizations push authenticity because they believe it builds trust. They are right. But not for the reason they think.

Trust is not built by showing your whole self. Trust is built by being consistent over time.

The leaders people trust most are the ones who show up the same way in a difficult conversation as they do in a celebration. Who behave the same when they are being watched as when they are not. Who make choices about who to be and then make those choices repeatedly, predictably, reliably.

Consistency is what feels authentic to the people around you. And consistency is a choice.

How This Applies Tomorrow

If you are working with leaders who are stuck in guilt about their "authenticity" at work, the reframe is simple.

You are not faking it. You are learning a skill.

The version of yourself that performs well in a board meeting is not a lie. It is a version of you that you are practicing until it becomes natural. Every time you show up that way, you get better at it. The discomfort fades.

The person who is most naturally introverted can become the leader everyone wants in the room. Not by changing who they are. By choosing how they want to show up and practicing that choice until it sticks.

Monday Action

This week, write down one specific version of yourself you are choosing to be in your role. Not a personality shift. Not a values change. A presence choice.

Something you can practice.

Then look for where you are already doing this naturally, even in small ways. Where are you already choosing this version. Build from there.

You do not have to be yourself at work. You have to be intentional.

Feel free to reach out if any of this resonates.

When you stop waiting to feel "authentically ready" and start choosing the version of yourself that serves your role, what opens up?

You're great at the work. Let's make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help developing intentional leadership presence, consider reaching out.

[jessstaffordcoaching.com](https://www.jessstaffordcoaching.com)

- **External References:**
- [Why Workplace Authenticity Is Overrated — Fortune (2025)](https://fortune.com/2025/10/09/why-is-workplace-authenticity-overrated-gen-z/)

- [Are You an Authentic Leader or an Authentic Jerk? — MIT Sloan Management Review](<https://sloanreview.mit.edu/article/are-you-an-authentic-leader-or-an-authentic-jerk/>)